The Famous Few: Size, Fame and Online Attention to 4,147 Hillforts in Britain and Ireland

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Abstract

Which ancient sites receive public attention, and does that attention follow archaeological importance? I link all 4,147 hillforts in the Atlas of Hillforts of Britain and Ireland to Wikidata and to the English, Welsh, Irish and Scottish Gaelic Wikipedias, and measure ten years (2016 to 2025) of human pageviews. Attention is extremely concentrated. 86% of hillforts have no English Wikipedia article. Across all sites the Gini coefficient of yearly reading is 0.98; 11 sites receive half of all reading and 161 receive 90 per cent. The most-read sites are mostly famous for later monuments built on them: the 445 sites reused after AD 400 or named as castles make up 11% of the Atlas but take 64% of reading. In multivariate models, size, legal scheduling and especially prior excavation predict whether a site has an article; excavation history and a castle name predict how much an article is read; access to towns and population barely matters. Reading is not seasonal, and its largest spikes follow editorial decisions, such as a front-page feature, or news of new discoveries. Coverage also differs sharply by nation and language: Welsh Wikipedia covers 38% of Welsh hillforts, while English Wikipedia covers only 3.6% of those in the Republic of Ireland. Online attention to the past is governed by the same cumulative, gatekept dynamics found on social media platforms: it follows prior attention more than intrinsic importance.

Keywords: hillforts; attention economy; Wikipedia pageviews; heritage; digital trace data; cumulative advantage; Iron Age; public archaeology

1 Introduction

Attention is scarce, and how it is distributed is a political and cultural question as much as a technical one. Most research on the attention economy studies news, entertainment and social media (Webster, 2014). My own work has examined how attention is distributed across political parties, leaders and posts on Facebook (Hotham, 2021). A recurring finding in that literature is that attention is highly unequal and cumulative: items that already have attention attract more (Merton, 1968; Salganik et al., 2006).

This paper asks the same question of the past. Britain and Ireland contain several thousand hillforts: enclosures, mostly of the later Bronze Age and Iron Age, defined by one or more

earthwork or stone ramparts. Thanks to the Atlas of Hillforts of Britain and Ireland (Lock and Ralston, 2017, 2022), every known example has been recorded to a common standard, including its size, number of ramparts, legal protection, dating evidence and investigation history. This makes hillforts an unusually clean test case. They form a single, well-defined class of monument, documented consistently across four nations, with measurable markers of archaeological significance.

If public attention followed archaeological importance, we would expect larger, more complex, better-dated and more thoroughly excavated sites to receive more of it. If attention instead followed fame and convenience, we would expect it to concentrate on sites with famous names, later monuments, or easy access. I test these expectations using Wikipedia article coverage and pageviews, a widely used measure of public interest (Mestyán et al., 2013).

The answer is that attention follows prior attention. Most hillforts have no article. Among those that do, reading is dominated by a handful of sites, most of them famous for medieval castles built on top of prehistoric forts. Size matters, but weakly. One of the most consistent predictors of attention is the intensity of past archaeological investigation, which suggests a feedback loop between expert and public attention. Access barely matters, reading is not seasonal, and the largest bursts of attention are handed out by editors.

2 Data and methods

2.1 Hillforts

The unit of analysis is the hillfort record in the Atlas of Hillforts of Britain and Ireland (Lock and Ralston, 2017), accessed through the copy of the Atlas source data released with the Hillforts Primer (Middleton, 2024a,b). The data contain 4,147 records: 1,225 in England, 1,695 in Scotland, 690 in Wales, 475 in the Republic of Ireland, 32 in Northern Ireland and 30 on the Isle of Man. From the Atlas I take: enclosed area in hectares (recorded for 3,807 sites); maximum number of ramparts; whether the site is a scheduled monument; the number of recorded excavations; whether any dating evidence exists; and whether the site shows activity in the Roman period (AD 50 to 400) or after AD 400. I also code two name cues: whether the site name contains "castle", and whether it contains a storied name (Arthur, Caesar, giant, devil, king, queen, maiden, fairy, druid, Merlin, Danes, Romans, Vespasian, Alfred or Robin). Access is measured by the distance to the nearest town of 10,000 or more people and the population of all places within 25 km, both from GeoNames, and by whether the Atlas records the site as coastal.

2.2 Articles and reading

Every Atlas record has a Wikidata item carrying its Atlas identifier (property P4102). I collected the English, Welsh, Irish and Scottish Gaelic Wikipedia articles linked to each item. Because many relevant articles are attached to a different item (a castle, a hill, a headland), I added two matching passes for sites with no linked article. First, I matched Atlas sites to Wikidata items of hillfort, fort and archaeological-site classes in the UK and Ireland within 500 metres that shared a distinctive name word. Second, I queried English Wikipedia's geographic search around each

site and accepted the nearest article within the site's radius plus 300 metres whose title shared a distinctive word with the Atlas name and named a landform or monument (a hill, head, island, castle, camp or similar), excluding settlements, churches and other unrelated features. These rules are deliberately conservative. In total, 565 sites (13.6%) have an English article and 766 (18.5%) have an article in at least one of the four languages.

Reading is measured as monthly human pageviews (excluding automated agents) from the Wikimedia REST API, January 2016 to December 2025, summed across the four languages and expressed as an annual average. Sites without articles have zero reading. I also recorded the number of files in each site's Wikimedia Commons category, where one exists, and the heritage body that owns or operates the site on Wikidata.

I had intended to add Google Maps review counts as a second, visit-based measure. Google's Maps Platform terms do not allow place content to be scraped or cached for analysis, so this measure is not included. A measure of car parking near each site from OpenStreetMap was also planned but could not be collected reliably during the study period; this is a limitation discussed below.

2.3 Analysis

I first describe the distribution of attention using coverage rates, cumulative shares and Gini coefficients. I then estimate two models for the 3,807 sites with a recorded area. The first is a logistic regression of having an English article. The second is an OLS regression of log yearly reading for the 526 sites with an English article and positive reading. Area, excavations, distance and population enter as base-2 logarithms, so their coefficients describe the effect of a doubling. Both models include nation controls and heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. A third model, OLS of $\log(1 + \text{reading})$ for all sites, combines both margins and is reported as a robustness check.

3 Results

3.1 Most hillforts have no article

86% of hillforts have no English Wikipedia article (Table 1). Coverage varies sharply by nation. English Wikipedia covers 29% of hillforts in England, 11% in Wales, 7% in Scotland and 3.6% in the Republic of Ireland. Welsh Wikipedia is the exception: it has articles on 38% of Welsh hillforts, more than English Wikipedia covers in any nation. The Irish and Scottish Gaelic Wikipedias cover almost none.

Table 1: Article coverage and reading by nation.

Nation	Sites	English	Welsh	Irish/Gaelic	Any	Reads per year
England	1,225	28.7%	0.2%	0.1%	28.7%	1,350,419
Isle of Man	30	6.7%	0.0%	0.0%	6.7%	16,090
Northern Ireland	32	6.2%	0.0%	0.0%	6.2%	2,407
Republic of Ireland	475	3.6%	0.2%	0.6%	3.6%	84,811
Scotland	1,695	6.7%	0.1%	0.8%	6.7%	1,045,433
Wales	690	11.4%	38.4%	0.1%	40.6%	150,978

3.2 Attention is extremely concentrated

Across all sites, the Gini coefficient of yearly reading is 0.98, and 0.82 among sites with an English article. Over the ten years the four Wikipedias served about 26.5 million human pageviews of hillfort articles. The single most-read site, Edinburgh Castle, accounts for 12% of all reading; the top four account for 34%; 11 sites account for half and 161 for 90 per cent (Figure 1). The median English article is read about 831 times a year.

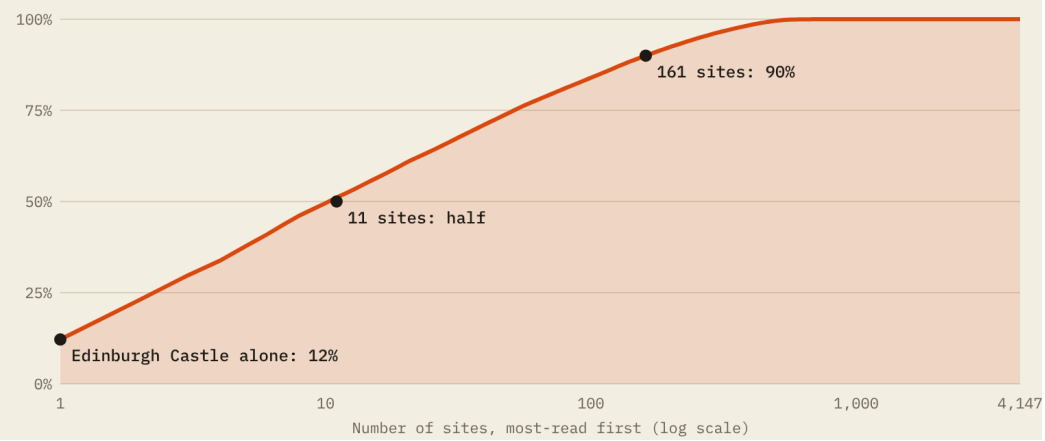


Figure 1: Cumulative share of reading, with sites ranked from most to least read (horizontal axis log scale).

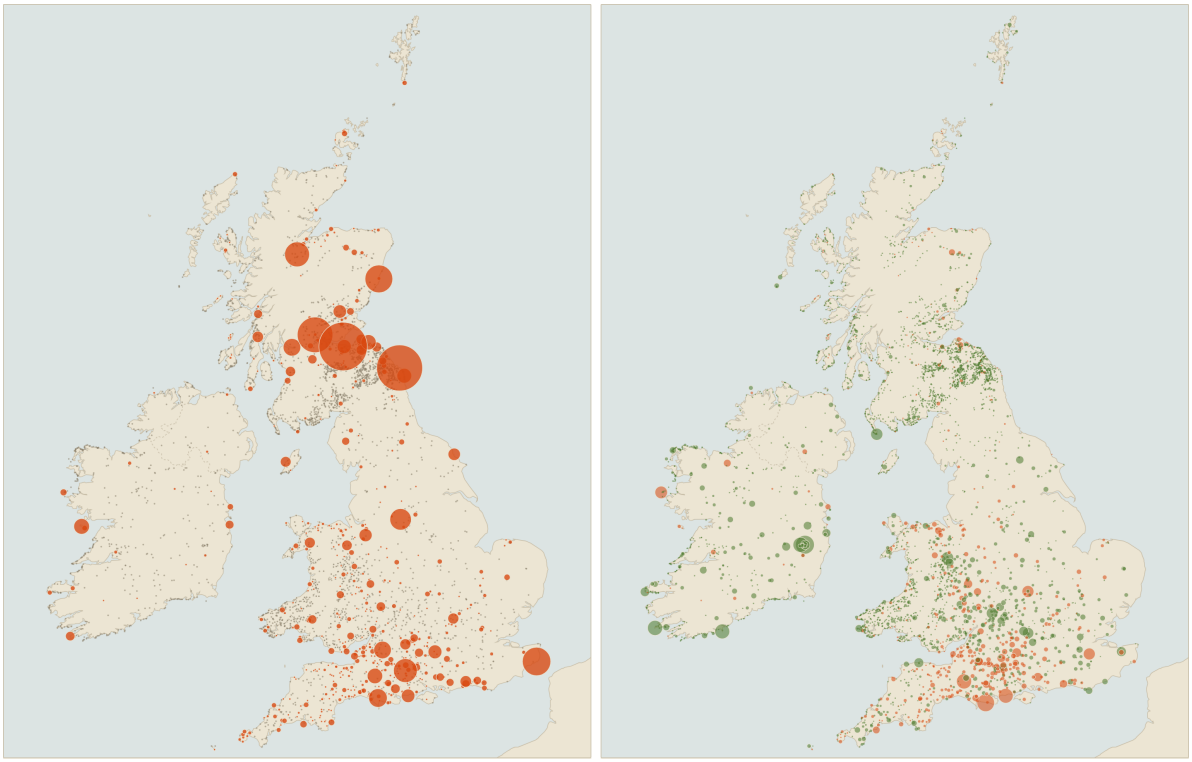


Figure 2: All 4,147 Atlas hillforts. Left: dots sized by yearly reading (grey = no English article). Right: dots sized by enclosed area (orange = has an English article).

Table 2: The fifteen most-read hillforts. Reuse = activity after AD 400 or a castle name.

	Site	Nation	Area (ha)	Reuse	Reads per year
1	Edinburgh Castle, City of Edinburgh	Scotland		yes	322,279
2	Bamburgh Castle, Northumberland	England		yes	289,636
3	Stirling Castle, Stirling	Scotland		yes	173,125
4	Dover Castle, Kent	England	6.0	yes	110,340
5	Dunnottar Castle, Aberdeenshire	Scotland		yes	105,054
6	Urquhart Castle, Highland	Scotland	0.05	yes	84,235
7	Old Sarum, Wiltshire	England	12.0		76,992
8	Mam Tor, Derbyshire	England	6.4		62,920
9	Maiden Castle, Winterborne St Martin, Dorset	England	18.5	yes	46,638
10	Dumbarton Castle, West Dunbartonshire	Scotland		yes	41,908
11	Little Solsbury Hill Camp, Bath and NE Somerset	England	7.9		41,441
12	Dún Aonghasa, Galway	Ireland	5.7		33,244
13	Cadbury Castle, South Cadbury, Somerset	England	7.5	yes	31,995
14	Dunbar, Castle Park, East Lothian	Scotland	0.56	yes	31,613
15	Dunstanburgh Castle, Northumberland	England		yes	29,179

3.3 Size helps, but weakly

The probability of having an English article rises with size (Figure 3): 5% in the smallest tenth of sites by area and 39% in the largest (4 hectares and above). But most large hillforts are still unwritten, and among sites with articles the relationship between area and reading is loose

(Figure 4).

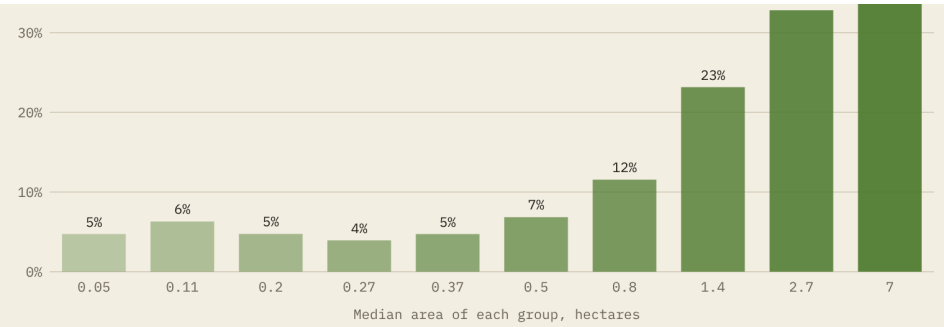


Figure 3: Share of hillforts with an English article, by decile of enclosed area. Labels show the median area of each decile in hectares.

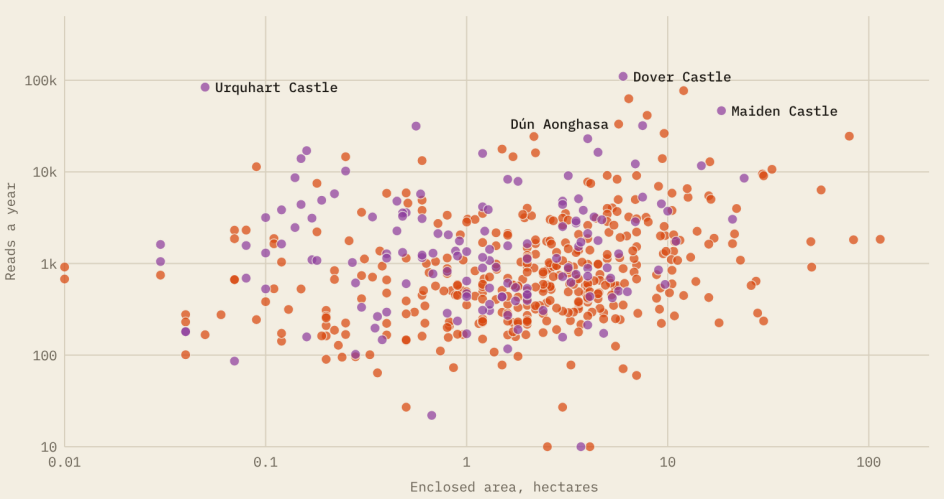


Figure 4: Enclosed area against yearly reading for sites with an English article (both axes log scale). Plum: sites reused after AD 400 or named as castles.

3.4 The castle on top

The most-read sites are mostly famous for something other than their prehistoric fort. Edinburgh, Bamburgh, Stirling, Dover, Dunnottar and Urquhart are in the Atlas because an early fort lies beneath a medieval castle. The rule undercounts reuse: Old Sarum, the seventh most-read site, is known mainly for its Norman castle and first cathedral, but the Atlas does not record post-400 dating for it. Across the dataset, sites reused after AD 400 or carrying "castle" in their name make up 11% of the Atlas and receive 64% of reading. Among mainly prehistoric sites, the most-read are Mam Tor in the Peak District, a popular hill walk; Maiden Castle in Dorset; Little Solsbury Hill near Bath (the subject of a well-known 1977 Peter Gabriel song); Dún Aonghasa on Inis Mór; and Cadbury Castle in Somerset, long associated with Camelot.

3.5 What predicts attention

Table 3 and Figure 5 report the models. Three importance measures predict having an article: area (odds ratio 1.29 per doubling), scheduled status (3.74) and excavations (1.65 per dou-

bling). Reuse after AD 400 (4.09), Roman-period activity (1.61) and a castle name (2.99) also predict coverage. Ramparts, dating, coast, distance to a town and nearby population do not. Among sites with an article, the strongest predictors of reading are excavations (+58% per doubling), a castle name (+82%) and area (+16% per doubling). Access measures add almost nothing. Entered as separate blocks, the importance variables explain 0.24 (McFadden pseudo-R^2) of coverage and 0.16 (R^2) of reading among articles; fame cues explain 0.09 and 0.07; access explains 0.09 and 0.03.

Table 3: Models of attention. (1) Logistic regression of having an English article, odds ratios. (2) OLS of log yearly reading for sites with an English article, shown as percentage change. (3) OLS of log(1 + yearly reading), all sites, coefficients. Area, excavations, distance and population are base-2 logs. All models include nation controls; robust standard errors. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

	(1) OR	95% CI	(2) Change	95% CI	(3) b
Twice the enclosed area	1.29***	[1.21, 1.38]	+16%***	[+9, +24]	+0.18***
Multiple ramparts	0.90	[0.72, 1.13]	+12%	[-10, +41]	-0.02
Legally scheduled	3.74***	[2.70, 5.18]	+3%	[-31, +55]	+0.74***
Twice the excavations	1.65***	[1.36, 2.00]	+58%***	[+33, +86]	+0.71***
Has a date	1.31	[0.94, 1.83]	+7%	[-18, +40]	+0.54**
Reused after AD 400	4.09***	[2.31, 7.25]	+13%	[-32, +90]	+0.93**
Roman-period activity	1.61*	[1.04, 2.49]	+24%	[-9, +68]	+0.78**
Storied name (Arthur, Caesar, giant...)	1.19	[0.64, 2.23]	+38%	[-19, +135]	+0.51
"Castle" in the name	2.99***	[2.21, 4.05]	+82%***	[+36, +142]	+1.09***
Coastal	1.31	[0.90, 1.90]	+47%	[-3, +124]	+0.22*
Twice as far from a town	0.96	[0.83, 1.11]	-11%	[-21, +1]	-0.04
Twice the nearby population	1.07	[0.99, 1.16]	-0%	[-7, +7]	+0.02
Observations	3,807		526		3,807
Pseudo-R^2 / R^2	0.28		0.23		0.28

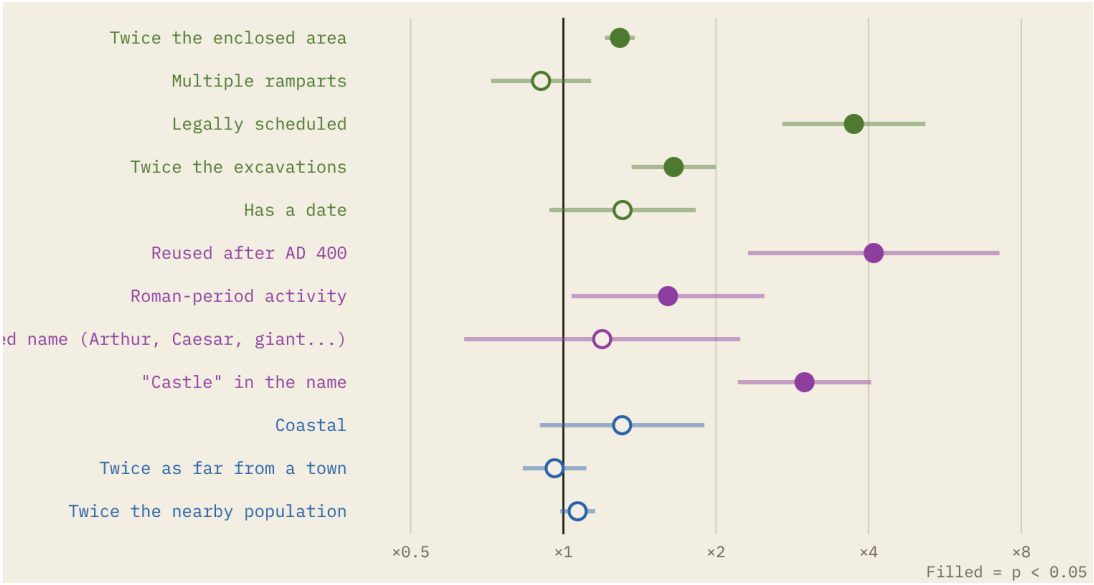


Figure 5: Odds ratios for having an English article, with 95% intervals. Filled markers: $p < 0.05$. Green: importance; plum: fame and reuse; blue: access.

3.6 Timing: no season, big bursts

Visits to heritage sites in Britain and Ireland are strongly seasonal. Wikipedia reading of hillforts is not. For the 305 prehistoric sites with at least 300 reads a year, the median site's reading in each calendar month lies within about 9% of its monthly average, with a small dip in November and December. The largest deviations are bursts (Figure 6). When Cefnllys Castle was the English Wikipedia front-page featured article on 24 December 2020, its reading that month was about 280 times its median. The Trundle had a similar spike after its front-page appearance on 15 January 2022. News of discoveries produces smaller but visible spikes, as at Tap o' Noth in May 2020 (University of Aberdeen, 2020) and at Stanwick when the Melsonby hoard was announced in March 2025 (Yorkshire Museum, 2025).

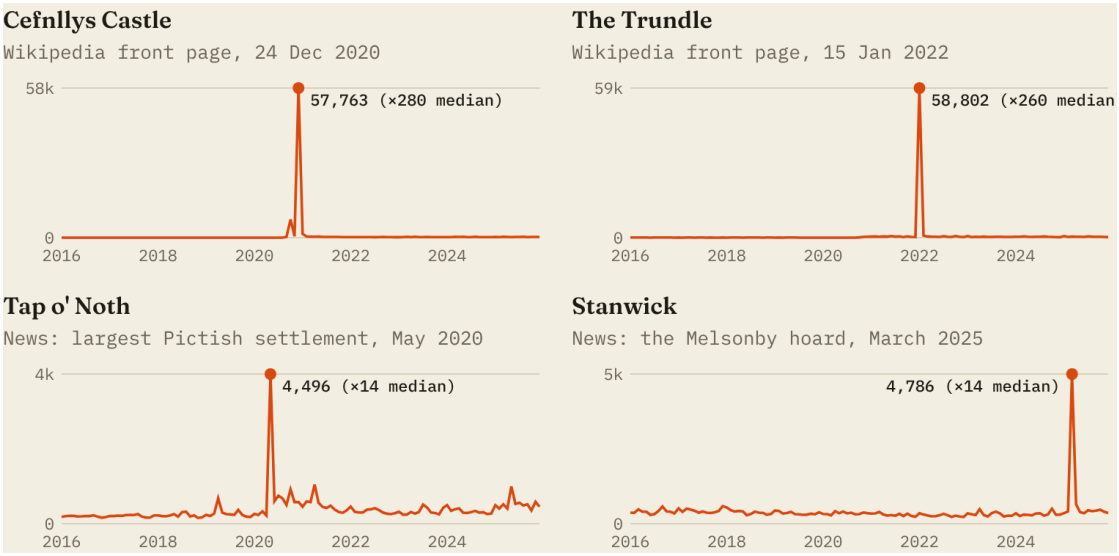


Figure 6: Monthly English Wikipedia pageviews, 2016 to 2025, for four sites with large single-month spikes. Each panel has its own scale.

3.7 Forgotten giants

Table 4 lists the largest hillforts with no article in any of the four languages. Half are in Ireland, including the four largest; the biggest of all is Spinans Hill in County Wicklow, which at 130 hectares is the largest enclosure in the Atlas.

Table 4: The largest hillforts with no Wikipedia article in English, Welsh, Irish or Scottish Gaelic.

Site	Nation	Area (ha)	Ramparts	Scheduled	Excavations
Spinans Hill 2, Wicklow	Ireland	130.0	2		0
Tinoran, Wicklow	Ireland	84.0	5		0
Ballynacarriga, Cork	Ireland	83.5	5		0
Downmacpatrick	Ireland	81.2	0		1
Mull of Galloway, Dumfries & Galloway	Scotland	54.0	3	yes	1
Nottingham Hill Camp, Gloucestershire	England	48.6	3	yes	2
Dyke Hills, Oxfordshire	England	46.0	2	yes	1
Countisbury Castle, Devon	England	35.0	1	yes	0
Homestall Wood, Kent	England	35.0	1		0
Abingdon, The Vineyard, Oxfordshire	England	33.0	3		1
Brusselstown Ring, Wicklow	Ireland	32.43	2		0
Coumeenoole North/Com Dhêneol Thuaidh, Kerry	Ireland	32.2	1		0

4 Discussion

Three conclusions follow. First, online attention to the past is concentrated to a degree that resembles, and exceeds, attention on commercial platforms. The pattern fits models of cumulative advantage, in which early attention compounds (Merton, 1968; Salganik et al., 2006), and the long-tail picture of cultural markets (Anderson, 2006): a few hits and thousands of items with no audience at all.

Second, public attention tracks prior expert attention. Excavation history predicts both whether an article exists and how much it is read, even with size and legal status held constant. The direction of causation cannot be settled with these data. Excavated sites generate the publications that Wikipedia editors cite, but famous sites also attract excavation. Either way, public and expert attention reinforce each other. This matters for heritage policy: under-investigated sites, including some of the largest in these islands, are invisible twice over.

Third, gatekeeping persists on participatory platforms. The largest bursts of attention follow editorial choices such as featured-article selection, and news coverage of new research. Language communities act as gatekeepers too. The contrast between Welsh coverage of Welsh hillforts and the near-absence of articles on Irish hillforts shows that the volunteer communities who write about the past, not the monuments themselves, determine what can be read. Archaeology as popular culture is shaped by stories and later associations as much as by evidence (Holtorf, 2005); the castle-on-top effect is a measurable instance of that.

4.1 Limitations

Wikipedia reading is a measure of online interest, not of visits. I could not include Google review counts because of Google's terms, and could not reliably measure car parking or other visitor infrastructure, so the "access" effects estimated here capture only distance and population. Article matching is conservative and will miss some articles filed under other names, which would slightly understate coverage. The castle and storied-name cues are simple text

rules. Finally, the models are descriptive: they show what attention is associated with, not what causes it.

5 Conclusion

Public attention to Britain and Ireland's hillforts does not follow their archaeological importance in any simple way. It follows prior attention: from archaeologists, from medieval builders who put castles on old forts, from storytellers, and from the editors and language communities who decide what gets written and featured. The same dynamics that structure attention on social media structure attention to the past.

Data availability

The site-level dataset (Atlas variables, matched articles, yearly reading and Commons counts), monthly pageview series and analysis code are available at `https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/famous-few` and in the Zenodo record for this paper (`https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23649936`). A non-technical summary is at `https://blog.tristanhotham.com/2026/10/25/the-famous-few/`. An interactive version of the analysis is at `https://tristan-hotham.github.io/famous-few/`. Atlas data are used under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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Use of AI

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude.

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